a special aircraft to take him to Hong Kong so he could catch the Air-India flight to New Delhi the same afternoon.

The liaison relationship was established soon thereafter, but the PM's visit had to wait till 1988, when Rajiv Gandhi paid a visit to China. Incidentally, I was at that time joint secretary, looking after China analysis, and was asked to prepare notes in connection with that visit. Kao was also involved in some other foreign policy-related visits and a couple of secret operations related to internal matters. Here, however, we need to examine Kao's role in Op-2 only.

B. Raman and two other officers from the R&AW accompanied Kao to London and Zurich to meet 'Khalistani elements' and seek their cooperation in getting Bhindranwale and other extremist elements to vacate the Golden Temple complex. Raman's job was to discreetly record their conversations, transcribe them and give Kao the transcripts in order to brief Indira Gandhi on his return. It appears the visit took place in January–February 1984, by which time Bhindranwale had shifted to the Akal Takht (15 December 1983).

According to Raman, 'A Khalistani leader from the US, who met Kao at Zurich, offered to try to help if he was allowed to go into the Golden Temple and meet Bhindranwale. As proof of his good will, he claimed that the Khalistani elements in the US had planned to kill the R&AW officer in Washington DC, but he prevented them from doing so. I was told that Indira Gandhi was against accepting his proposal to send him inside the temple. She felt that if this person also stayed behind and joined Bhindranwale it could add to the problem of the Government of India.' [8]

Though Raman has not named him, it is obvious that the 'Khalistani leader' he refers to was the Washington DC-based Ganga Singh Dhillon, head of the Nankana Sahib Foundation. Dhillon was earlier allowed, if not encouraged, to visit Chandigarh in mid-March 1981 to preside over a Sikh education conference, where he had moved a resolution for the creation of Khalistan. His visit suited the Congress party at that time. Now it did not. The time was not opportune to allow a US national of his background to meet